THE RISE OF PLANTATION TOURISM

The hill tracts of Tamil Nadu offer unique plantation holidays which are all about interesting experiences, relaxation, and immersion in nature.

Tamil Nadu's hill tracts are home to numerous tea, coffee and spice plantations which have emerged as interesting tourist experiences. The plantation owners struck upon the smart idea of offering the sprawling managers' bungalows—many of them dating from the colonial era—to tourists for stays. Along with the stay came an opportunity to observe the inner workings of a plantation at close quarters. Plantation holidays are a win-win, a great way for plantation owners to supplement their agricultural income, while allowing visitors a window into the little known yet a fascinating world of plantations.

Hill stations like Ooty, Coonoor, Kodaikanal, Megamalai, Yercaud and Valparai are home to several colonial-era plantation bungalows which have now been put to good use, creating a unique tourist experience. Besides enjoying a stay in the privacy of a lavish bungalow, guests also get to visit the on-site factories to understand the process of tea or coffee manufacturing.

In the Nilgiris, the Tranquilitea Tea Lounge offers an immersive tea tasting experience to visitors. It also offers luxurious plantation stays at its properties in Ooty and Coonoor. Another option in the Nilgiris is the over 150-year-old Balmaadi Estate which lies 50 kilometres from Ooty and grows a variety of crops like coffee, tea, cardamom, and stevia. This is the land of the Todas and interacting with members of this graceful tribe can be an unforgettable experience.

The popular hill station of Kodaikanal is home to several coffee plantations, including Kodai Vel Farms and Elephant Valley Camp. The latter offers accommodation in the lap of nature next to a river where elephants can sometimes be spotted.

Another major hub of plantation tourism is Valparai, a hill station close to Pollachi. The winding drive to Valparai, with tea gardens on each side, is nothing short of magical. Not only are there tea and coffee plantations here, the area is also studded with lush forests and wildlife sanctuaries. Popular tourist sights include the massive Sholayar Dam and the Anaimalai Tiger Reserve. There are also numerous waterfalls and valleys to explore. The plantation experience here includes the Woodbriar Valparai Tea Estate. There are four factories and over 2,000 hectares of tea plantations here. The bungalows themselves offer mesmerising views of the surrounding countryside.

Megamalai in Tamil Nadu's Theni district also attracts those seeking the plantation experience. A long dam, evergreen forests and, of course, charming tea plantation bungalows are the highlights here.

The district of Kanniyakumari offers the plantation experience too, except the plantations here are mostly rubber. The Kani tribe who inhabit the forests of the district have their unique customs and traditions. Anantya Resorts, on the banks of the Chittar Lake, is set inside a 1,000-acre rubber plantation and offers farm visits, interactions with the Kani tribe and other interesting experiences.

Like the estates mentioned, there are many more spread across the balmy hills of Tamil Nadu waiting to give you a taste of the planter's life.

Plantation holidays are a great way to experience a unique aspect of Tamil Nadu. Few visitor experiences are so immersive and private. Plantation bungalow stays got a big boost in the COVID era, because they naturally offer seclusion, tranquillity and relaxing holidays in one spot—perfect for unwinding with the entire family in the safety of one's bungalow. And it looks like they are getting more popular by the day.



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